



CHAPTER 1

The King's Measure

On the ninth day of the occupation, the soldiers came for the seed.

Tobious was waiting outside the granary when the gate's shadow reached the last storage jar. He counted seven soldiers, a scribe, and four donkeys carrying empty panniers. A boy followed them with a water jug. He was too young to have worked a harvest after dark, but someone had put a rope around his neck, like the ropes on the two prisoners beside the well.

Tobious looked away before the boy could see him.

Beside him, Mariya nudged a small board with her foot. Fourteen pebbles lay on it, one for each jar they had inspected. She drew three apart from the others.

"Let me finish before you say anything."

"If they take these, we'll have nothing to sow."

"I know."

She tied her hair back again. Flour marked her temple where she had wiped away sweat at the mill. She was wearing the same shawl she had worn on the night of the attack. One end had burned; she had cut it on a slant to stop it fraying.

"You said three jars."

"And I'm still trying to get three jars."

Boots struck the paving. Tobious folded his hands behind his back so the soldiers would not see them close.

From the granary yard, Aras fell away in terraces toward the bay. Mud-brick houses stood on stone foundations, divided by narrow stairs and courtyards where figs should have been drying. Below them lay the

harvested barley fields. The olives grew higher up, leaning inland from the sea wind.

Smoke still rose from the boatbuilder's house. Tobious no longer noticed the smell. People returning from the groves covered their noses when they passed it.

Across the valley, the red cloth of Telassar flew above the old ruler's house. That building had not burned. The invaders had spared its roof, its oil stores, its stables. Of all the promises the citadel had made to Aras, only its walls remained useful. They now sheltered the men who had broken the village gate.

The officer stopped in front of Mariya. A bronze corselet covered his chest; its edges rasped against the padded cloth beneath as he breathed. The other soldiers wore thick tunics and carried spears and hide shields. Without waiting for orders, they took their places on either side of the granary door.

Mariya bowed just enough.

"Fourteen jars. Eleven for the palace. Three for sowing after the rains."

The scribe crouched and rested a clay tablet on his knee. From a fold in his clothes he took a pointed stylus.

"Open them," the officer said.

Tobious lifted the lid from the nearest jar. Barley filled it almost to the neck. He had selected those grains himself: whole, heavy, untouched by beetles. Seed from the patch that had remained standing when last season's winds flattened half the slope.

A soldier dipped a wooden measure into it.

Tobious watched the rim.

"That's too deep."

Mariya turned her head.

The soldier stopped. "What?"

"Your measure." Tobious pointed to a dark line around the wood.

"The rim used to end there. You've added another band."

The officer took it from the soldier. He turned it once, examined the join, and handed it back.

"That's the palace measure."

"It isn't the one you brought yesterday."

"Yesterday we collected oil."

"We know how much grain is in this store."

"Good. You'll find it easier to count what's left."

The stylus moved across the clay. The scribe had not looked inside a single jar.

Tobious stepped forward. Mariya caught his wrist.

"Those three are seed," she told the officer. "Take them and next year you'll have to bring food here before you can collect anything."

The man considered her.

"How many can still plough?"

"Nineteen. Twenty-one if you release the two beside the well."

"Oxen?"

"Three healthy pairs."

Tobious looked at her. Yesterday there had been four.

"Two jars," the officer said. "Load the rest."

"Three."

He pointed with his whip handle. "Mark those two."

The scribe pressed lumps of damp clay around the cords securing their lids. He lifted a carved stone from the thong at his neck and stamped each lump. A bull stood in the impressions, its head lowered.

Mariya's fingers remained around Tobious's wrist. Then she let go.

"Those two are not to be touched."

The officer was already turning to supervise the loading.

The soldiers poured barley into sacks. Grains scattered across the paving—not many, but enough to make Tobious kneel and gather them. He could not leave them to be trodden underfoot.

When he stood, a soldier was dragging the third jar toward the threshold. A leaf had been scratched into the clay beside its handle.

That one was his.

His mother had made the mark before the clay dried, years ago, so they could find their jar among the things held in common. At the end of every harvest, Tobious scrubbed its inside by hand and filled it again. It held the seed for his field, and seed entrusted to him by the family whose house had become the soldiers' kitchen.

"Wait."

The soldier kept dragging.

Tobious caught the other handle.

"I said wait."

"Let go."

"Take my share of the food. Leave this."

The man pulled harder. The base struck the threshold. A small, dry sound came from the clay.

Tobious did not think of the seven spears. He saw a crack running down beneath the leaf.

He hauled the jar toward him.

The spear shaft struck his wrist.

His grip opened. Before he could catch the handle again, the shield's rim drove into his breastbone and emptied his lungs. He stumbled backward, trying to keep his feet. A boot swept his ankle out from under him.

His cheek hit the paving.

For a moment he could see only barley. One grain had lodged between two stones. An ant walked across it.

Tobious pressed his palms against the ground. His right knuckles scraped the stone as he pulled that hand free from beneath him.

A spear point touched the back of his neck.

"Stay down."

He stopped moving.

At the gate, nine days ago, he had stopped like this. He had been holding a wooden fork then. A man with a shield had come so close that Tobious could no longer bring the tines around. He remembered the wood breaking. Someone had fallen beside him. His own hand had searched the wall for an opening, somewhere narrow enough that the spear could not follow.

He still did not know how to get past a shield.

"He's your sluice worker," Mariya said.

Footsteps approached.

"And?" the officer asked.

"Your men came yesterday. They wanted someone who knew the channels beneath the old storehouse. I gave them his name."

The spear point pressed a little harder.

"Tobious. He repairs the water gates every season."

The officer told the scribe to check another tablet. When the man nodded, the officer crouched beside Tobious's head.

"You'll start now."

He gripped Tobious's hair and lifted his face.

"Under the hill. Until the work is done."

He let go. Tobious's cheek struck the stone again.

When the spear was lifted, he did not immediately rise. The soldiers resumed loading. Wood scraped the sides of the jars, and the grain poured into their sacks. He could hear next year's fields leaving the village.

Mariya waited until they had moved away before kneeling beside him.

"Can you breathe?"

He nodded.

"Look at me."

He turned his head. Beyond her shoulder, the people who had been watching were returning to their work. A woman swept spilled barley into a fold of her dress.

"We still have two," Mariya said quietly. "Help me keep them."

Tobious could not answer.



Behind the granary, Mariya wet the corner of a cloth and cleaned the blood from his lip.

He supported his right wrist with his left hand. The skin had not yet changed colour, but whenever he moved his fingers, pain travelled to his elbow.

"You gave them my name?"

"They're taking workers from every household. I offered someone who actually knew the channels."

"Without asking me."

She stopped wiping.

"You were on Samon's roof until dark yesterday. This morning you came before sunrise. I hadn't had a chance."

"They killed people at the gate. Now I'm supposed to work for them?"

"Right now you're alive because they need the work done."

She said it without raising her voice. That made it harder to argue.

She returned to his lip, and this time he let her.

In the lower yard, the water boy struggled to lift his jug onto a donkey's back. A soldier helped him, then tugged the rope around his neck to make him follow.

"They'll come back," Tobious said. "When those two jars are empty, they'll come back."

"That's why we have to sow."

"So they can take it again?"

Mariya folded the bloodied side of the cloth inward.

"I want the people here to keep eating until we find another way."

Tobious studied his right hand. It could lift a sack Mariya could not shift alone. He could dig until sunset, reset the stones of a terrace wall, hold an ox frightened by fire.

In front of the granary, none of it had bought him time to strike back.

"If I'd had a sword—"

"He would have taken it from you."

Tobious looked up.

She lowered the cloth into the bowl. Blood clouded the water.

"I saw it, Tobi."

He almost told her to leave. The words were behind his teeth when he noticed the split skin beneath her thumb, and the flour still caught in her hair. She had not eaten since they opened the granary.

He reached into the fold of cloth at his waist and took out half a barley loaf. It had been flattened beneath him when he fell.

He broke it in two.

Mariya accepted the smaller piece, inspected it, then exchanged it for the one in his hand.

They ate without speaking.



The old storehouse lay beneath the terrace where Aras kept its images of the dead. Steps descended between two walls so old that no one remembered who had built them. The houses above had fallen and been rebuilt three times. The stones below had not shifted even in the earthquake that brought down the western gate, when Tobious was still small enough to be carried on someone's back.

A wooden fence usually barred the stairs. Today it was firewood.

Three soldiers were lowering the statue of the woman with the bowl from its place beside the well. They had wrapped her head in cloth to keep it from breaking.

Tobious slowed.

As a child, he had been taught to wet the statue's feet with the first water he drew to drink. The old people said the spring remembered a grateful household. He had never decided whether he believed them. But the pale circle where she had stood made him want to put something there.

A guard pushed him between the shoulders with a spear shaft.

"Down."

The air below was cooler and smelled of lamp oil. Six people from Aras were clearing rubble and sediment from a passage. Tobious recognized Samon by his bent back. The older man was fastening a rope around a block of stone.

"What's wrong with your hand?" he asked.

"Someone hit it."

Samon looked at his lip, then offered him the unfinished knot.

"Use the other one."

He asked nothing else.

The passage ended in a circular chamber. Water seeped through the eastern wall and stood ankle-deep across the floor. In the centre, the workers had uncovered an opening beneath a stone slab. Another short flight of steps led down into it.

A Telassari overseer waited there with a three-wicked lamp. A leather tube hung at his waist. None of the other soldiers carried one.

"You know the channels?"

Tobious nodded.

The man pointed at the water. "Get it out."

Tobious crouched beside the wall. Moss filled the joints, but the lower stones were clean, worn by the flow. He felt along the floor until his fingers found the drain.

A piece of broken pottery had lodged across its mouth. Mud and roots had caught behind it.

He pulled the shard free.

The water began to move. A faint current tugged at his ankles.

“Don't go down yet.”

The overseer already had one foot on the steps.

“Why?”

Tobious pointed at a dark line on the wall. “The water stood higher than the opening. That drain's been blocked a long time. There could still be a chamberful below.”

The man waited. Only a moment, but long enough for Tobious to feel something he had not felt all morning: his words had made some-one stop.

They lifted the mud out in baskets. Samon held a lamp while Tobious worked a wooden rod through the channel. His right wrist began to swell. He slowed, then changed his grip so he would not have to bend it.

As the water receded, a line appeared along the lowest step.

At first Tobious took it for a joint in the stone.

It was too straight.

The overseer opened his tube and withdrew a thin piece of hide covered in marks. He looked at the steps, checked the hide, then rolled it away before Tobious could make out anything more.

“The rest of you. Out.”

Samon glanced at Tobious.

“He stays.”

The workers gathered their baskets. Samon's footsteps paused at the entrance, then followed the others up the passage.

Only Tobious, the overseer, and a soldier guarding the stairs remained.

“What's down there?” Tobious asked.

“Storage.”

“Storehouse doors usually have handles.”

The overseer raised the lamp.

Tobious could see it clearly now: a black surface inside a stone frame, without hinges or sockets for a locking bar. It was wide enough for two people abreast. Mud crusted its lower edge, but the clean part did not reflect the lamp.

The overseer pointed to a recess in the frame.

“Clear that.”

Tobious used the corner of his clothes. A piece of green metal crossed the recess like a clamp. One end had broken away.

He touched it with the wooden rod.

A humming travelled through the wood into his palm.

He let go. The rod splashed into the water.

“Pick it up.”

“There's something inside.”

The overseer stepped closer. “I told you to clean it.”

Tobious glanced at the way out. The soldier on the steps shifted his spear into his right hand.

Tobious crouched again.

He drew the packed mud from behind the clamp with his cloth. Grit caught in the scrape across his knuckles. Without thinking, he wiped his hand against the edge of the recess, leaving a smear of blood.

The humming stopped.

The water around his feet went still.

The overseer lifted his head.

A line of light appeared on the black surface, level with Tobious's face.

He stumbled backward into the man's legs. The lamp swayed. All three flames stretched toward the opening, although Tobious felt no wind against his skin.

Something metallic moved inside the wall.

The overseer seized his shoulder.

“What did you do?”

Tobious did not answer. The light was widening.

Beyond it was sky.

Not another room. Not a passage lit with lamps.

Pale sky opened between buildings taller than the hills above Aras. Roads joined their upper reaches without a single pillar beneath them. Something long and silver passed along one, moving so quickly that Tobious only managed to follow its path after it had gone.

He could still feel cold water around his ankles. Behind him, the oil lamp hissed.

A man stood on the other side.

Shadow hid part of his face. His clothes fitted closely across his shoulders and arms, without folds or fastenings Tobious recognized. Blood escaped between the fingers pressed against his right ribs.

The man looked first at the overseer.

Then he found Tobious.

“Don't go with him.”

The voice was hoarse, broken by difficult breaths. Tobious knew the way it swallowed the ends of words, the effort to speak without letting anyone hear the fear.

He was listening to his own voice.

The overseer's grip tightened.

“Who is that?”

The man beyond the opening reached toward them. Behind him, a section of roadway bowed downward. Only then did Tobious understand that the small things falling from it were people.

“Tobi. Listen. They aren't looking for stores.”

A crash sounded in the passage behind him. The soldier on the stairs shouted to someone outside the chamber.

The man came close enough for the light to reach his face.

A long scar ran beneath his left eye. His hair was shorter. He looked older than Tobious, though Tobious could not have said by how many seasons.

“That door is what they came for. And now they know you can open it.”







CHAPTER 2

The Door Without Wind

The man with Tobious's face vanished while Tobious was still trying to reach him.

He pulled free of the overseer and stepped into the water. The black surface held a pale street, a broken road, the place where the man had stood. Tobious could see between the towers now. Whatever had fallen from the road was lost beneath them.

"Move back," the soldier on the stairs said.

Tobious heard him without understanding why the words were meant for him. He knew the line beneath the stranger's eye. He knew the voice. He had seen himself bleeding in a place beyond the span of any road he had ever imagined.

He reached for the light.

The overseer caught him by the collar. "Tell me what he said."

"You heard him."

"Tell me what you did."

In the passage behind the soldier, clay broke against stone. The water boy had dropped his jug. Tobious saw him appear at the bend, the rope still around his neck, one hand pressed to his mouth. The soldier turned long enough to shout at him to get out.

Tobious used the moment to take the wooden rod from the water. He pushed it toward the opening. It struck something hard where the distant street appeared to begin.

The impact jarred his swollen wrist. The rod slipped from his hand and fell into the chamber. He watched its ripples spread through the shallow water. None crossed the black line.

The man had not been standing in a doorway. Tobious had seen him as one sees a figure at the bottom of a still well: near enough to recognize, impossibly far to touch.

The towers thinned. Light passed through the man's empty place. Then the surface went black again.

For a breath, nobody moved.

"A picture," the soldier said.

The overseer shook his head. He had let go of Tobious and was already drawing the rolled hide from his tube. He held it close to the lamp, glancing from the marks to the green clamp in the frame.

"There should be a second contact."

"Should be?" Tobious asked.

The overseer lowered the drawing. There was a small circle pierced through the hide at its edge, and beside it a mark Tobious had seen on the soldier's requisition tablet that morning. Not a Telassari seal. Something stamped for men who could ask a king's soldiers to dig beneath graves.

The guard came down two steps. "Darran. We should fetch the captain."

So the overseer had a name. Darran examined the broken end of the clamp, then wedged the butt of the soldier's spare spear beneath it.

"Hold it there."

"The captain—"

"Will ask why you stood and watched it close."

The soldier braced the spear. Tobious backed toward the stairs. The boy was still at the bend, staring at the puddle of his lost water. He had a narrow face and a freshly rubbed patch of skin where the neck rope lay.

"Go up," Tobious told him.

The boy hesitated. He looked at the soldier.

Tobious understood. The boy had been ordered to bring water below. He did not yet know whether fear of this place was a reason anyone would accept.

Darran pushed the damaged clamp into its recess. Metal clicked against metal. Tobious felt pressure in his teeth, as if he were descend-

ing too quickly into deep water. The black surface bent inward. The lamp flames leaned toward it again.

This time the water moved.

A breeze touched his wet ankles and brought a smell he could not place: hot stone after rain, spoiled salt, something sweet beneath it. On the other side stood no shattered road. He saw a narrow place lined with pale walls, lit without a flame. The air at the threshold drew at his tunic.

"That's open," he said.

Darran's delight was so immediate it frightened him more than the breach.

"Keep it steady."

The soldier shifted his grip on the spear. In the bright passage beyond, a shape moved against the wall. Tobious thought it was a man approaching sideways to fit through a confined gap. Then the shape unfolded a second set of limbs.

The boy made a sound. Tobious turned and saw that the soldier had barred the stair with the length of his spear to keep him down. The order must have been to collect the broken jug. The boy crouched on the lowest step, too frightened to pass either way.

"Let him go," Tobious said.

The soldier did not look at him. His eyes were on the pale passage.

Something placed a hand against the threshold. It had too many joints and no nails. The hand went thin as smoke, then gathered itself again when the air flowed over it. A long shoulder followed. Where a chest ought to have been, Tobious saw the bright wall beyond, distorted as though viewed through flowing water.

The creature turned its head toward the boy.

The soldier released the clamp. The spear butt struck the chamber floor. He snatched his own weapon from against the stair and thrust. Bronze passed through the creature's hollow middle. The point rang against the far wall.

The creature closed around the shaft.

Its outline hardened for the space of a heartbeat. At its collar, where the neck narrowed into the empty torso, a dark knot appeared, wet and

ridged. The soldier pulled back. Bronze scraped it. The creature convulsed, and the smell of burned salt filled the chamber.

It struck him with one of its limbs. His hide shield took the blow and folded against him. The force drove him against the stair. He screamed for men above.

Tobious had already reached the boy.

He seized the rope at the child's neck and dragged him toward the passage. The rope caught under the soldier's foot. The boy fell. Tobious pulled again, felt the child's cry through the line, and stopped. With his left hand he found the knot. It had swollen wet and tight.

"Your name," he said, though he had no idea why he asked now.

The boy stared at him.

"What do they call you?"

"Lios."

"Lio. Stay against the wall."

He put the rope around a stone projection and hauled until it slipped free of the soldier's boot. His right hand failed him halfway through. He wound it once around his left forearm and drew Lios past the fallen man.

The soldier thrust again. This time the spear point found the collar knot. A spray of dark grains struck the steps. The creature pulled itself away from the bronze, and its lower limbs blurred. The guard tried to stand. Its hand closed around the back of his neck.

Tobious did not see the moment he died. He heard the spear fall.

Darran was at the clamp, trying to wrench it free with both hands. His lamp lay in the water, one wick still burning. As he pulled, the open passage widened another finger's breadth. The creature turned toward him. He abandoned the metal and stumbled past Tobious up the steps.

At the circular chamber, Samon and two other workers were running back with their baskets and ropes. They had heard the screaming. The sound of boots followed them from the upper stairs.

"Out," Darran ordered. "Seal it."

"How?" Samon said.

The creature entered the lower passage. Its limbs touched both walls. Each time it reached into the cooler air away from the light, it loosened at the edges, then drew substance again from the open threshold behind

it. Tobious saw the rhythm. It was not following them on a body it could keep for long. The doorway was feeding it.

He looked up at the rope Samon had tied around the lifted slab. One end ran through a notch in the masonry to a wooden lever on the chamber floor. He had used it an hour earlier to raise a basket of mud. The beam could shift the slab a little. It could not lift the whole doorway.

But the clamp sat beneath its near corner.

"Samon. The rope."

"Leave it."

"The metal is keeping the door open."

Lios pressed himself behind one of the basket carriers. Samon looked from him to the lower passage. His face changed. He had chosen to believe Tobious.

"You two, take the boy upstairs," he told the workers. "Tell them the stair is blocked."

One woman picked up Lios and carried him despite his protests that he could walk. The second worker ran beside her. Darran went after them, shouting for soldiers.

The creature came into the chamber.

It paused beside the lamp. Light passed through its open middle and made moving bars across the old stones. Tobious could see no eyes. Still, he felt it attend to the two men left there, and to the rope Samon was fastening around the lever.

"Where does the drain lead?" Samon asked.

"Down the west channel."

"Then if the roof comes?"

"The water goes that way."

Samon gave him a flat look. "I meant us."

They hauled. The rope stretched; the slab shifted no more than the width of Tobious's thumbnail. The creature moved. Samon let go to throw his basket at it. Wicker struck the wall. The Iwang flowed around it, thinning through the weave, then became heavy again as its collar came near the old stone.

Tobious took the lever with his left hand. The right could only steady it. He set his foot against the base and pulled until the wood

bent. The slab moved another fraction. A line of green metal appeared beneath it.

"A stone," he said. "Put it under."

Samon jammed a loose block into the gap. The Iwang struck at his back. He rolled away; one limb touched his tunic and left a hole through wool and skin. He made no sound. He only caught the rope again, grimacing.

Together they hauled. Tobious thought of the sluice gate above his own field, which never yielded to a straight pull after silt dried in the channel. Lift, wedge, release, lift again. The work did not care whether he was afraid.

The creature gathered itself. At the lower stair the guard's bronze spear lay half in the water. Tobious let go of the beam, caught it with his left hand, and swept the point across the Iwang's collar. He was not quick enough to stab. Bronze touched the knot for an instant. The creature recoiled from the contact.

"Now," Tobious said.

Samon pulled the rope alone. Tobious shoved the stone wedge into the new space. The slab dropped against it. The clamp snapped sideways out of its recess with a sound like a jar cracking at the kiln.

Air rushed down the passage. Then it stopped.

The light in the lower chamber began to narrow. The Iwang recoiled through the doorway, drawing itself along the wall with its limbs. It did not flee from Tobious or his poor strike. It followed the vanishing current. For a moment its collar knot hung in the passage, solid enough to cast a shadow. Then it passed beneath the slab and into the shrinking seam.

The floor lurched.

Samon threw himself at Tobious and drove him clear of the lever. Stone fell between them. A beam from the old ceiling hit Samon's left leg and pinned him below the knee.

Tobious landed against the wall. Dust filled his mouth. The chamber had gone dark except for the dropped lamp and a thin, declining line of light under the lower stone. It narrowed to nothing.

"Samon?"

"Here."

Tobious crawled to him. The older man's leg lay twisted beneath the beam. He touched it once and took his hand away.

"Don't pull me," Samon said.

The command came through clenched teeth. Tobious wanted to lift the stone. He could not even make his right hand close around its edge.

People shouted above. He called to them for poles, for wedges, for someone who knew how to set a crushed limb. He could name what was needed. That was the only strength he had left.

Darran returned with soldiers. They raised the beam a little at a time while Samon bit through a fold of his tunic. At the upper passage, Tobious saw Lios sitting against a wall, alive, his broken jug arranged carefully between his knees. Someone had cut the rope from his neck.

The boy lifted the two pieces of the jug when he saw Tobious. "It was full," he said.

"I know."

Lios looked back down the stair toward the dead guard. Tobious wished he had a better thing to say. He had saved the boy, and the boy would still have to remember the sound of that spear falling.

At the top of the stairs, the sky had begun to dim. Aras remained where it had been all day: the roofs, the bay, a line of women coming from the well with vessels balanced against their hips. The world had made room for a door, then closed around it without so much as changing the color of the evening.

Darran walked beside the men carrying Samon. He stopped when they reached the yard.

"The boy goes to his household," he told the soldiers. "The injured man gets a litter. This one stays."

He pointed at Tobious.

"Samon needs someone who can tell them how the beam fell."

"They can ask you tomorrow."

Tobious glanced at the empty place beside the well where the statue with the bowl had stood. He thought of the man in the impossible city, of blood at his right ribs, of a warning spoken too late to tell him what to do now.

Two soldiers took him by the arms. His swollen wrist flared when one tightened his grip. He went with them because Samon was breath-

ing on the litter, Lios had been carried into the lane, and the black surface beneath their feet had gone quiet.

He had closed a door. He had no idea how long it would stay closed.



CHAPTER 3

A Blade of Quiet Light

By morning, Tobious had learned which of the storehouse walls received the first heat of the sun. He had been awake long enough to watch its pale square of light travel over seven baskets of dried figs, a stack of broken jar lids, and the single sealed door.

The soldiers had taken his belt. They had left him his damp tunic because it was not worth having. His wrist had thickened during the night. Whenever he forgot and tried to use it, pain drew a sharp line up his arm.

Someone stopped outside the door. Tobious rose. It was a mistake; his knees had stiffened, and his shoulder struck the wall.

Darran came in carrying bread and a water bowl. He set both on a low crate just beyond Tobious's reach.

"You opened it by touching the green metal," he said.

Tobious stared at the bowl. "How is Samon?"

"The leg is still attached."

"That's not an answer."

"It is the answer I have." Darran drew the hide from its leather tube. In daylight it looked worse than the fragment Tobious had seen underground: old creases, a repair of neat stitches along one edge, several marks added in a different ink. "There was no command to put a hand inside the frame. What did you feel before the light?"

Tobious said nothing.

"If it opened once, it can open again."

"A man died the last time."

"Because a guard mistook something he did not understand for something he could stab."

Tobious remembered the bronze tip finding the creature's collar. Without it, he and Lios might have been the ones left on the stairs.

"He hurt it," he said. "For a moment."

Darran looked down at his drawing. "Did you see what was beyond?"

"A passage."

"Before that."

Tobious moved away from the crate. The thing he had seen before the passage was a city and a man whose face had been his own. He had thought of that face all night. In the time it took to draw a breath, he could recall the cut beneath the left eye, the strange close-fitted clothes, blood escaping through a hand. He could not recall where the buildings had ended. Perhaps they had not.

"You knew what was there," Tobious said.

"I knew enough to order you to clear it."

"Your own hands were free."

Darran's eyes lifted. His cheeks were marked by the narrow straps of a surveyor's leather cap. He wore no officer's bronze, but men with bronze had obeyed him below.

"Eat," he said. "You'll need your strength."

He left the bowl and bread on the crate as the door closed behind him.

Tobious waited until the steps had passed. Then he ate, because hunger could not punish Darran and would only weaken him.



The captain came shortly after noon. Captain Therren had removed his corselet. Without it, the man from the levy yard seemed narrower, but the effect vanished when he sat across from Tobious and asked how many workers the flooded chamber had required.

"Six," Tobious said. "Not counting me."

"How many did you send out?"

"I didn't. Darran did."

Therren nodded to the scribe at his shoulder. The man made a mark in the clay.

"He says you broke the apparatus."

"I broke the thing that held the doorway open."

"The apparatus."

"It was coming through."

"And you acted without his order."

Tobious looked at the clay tablet. A man could move the boundaries of an event merely by choosing where to press a stylus.

"Samon was hurt because he came back for me," he said. "A guard died because Darran opened it again. You can put that beside my name."

Therren did not glance at the scribe. "If I put every man's account beside his name, we would have no clay left before winter."

"Then you're measuring with the wrong jar."

The captain's mouth tightened, though Tobious could not tell whether he was hiding anger or something like amusement.

"You have a useful skill," Therren said. "That's why you're sitting in a room with bread instead of beside the dead guard."

There it was again: useful. It had saved him from a spear point in the granary yard, and it had brought him beneath the hill.

"Have Samon taken to Nerissa," Tobious said. "She sets limbs. He needs clean water and people who know him."

"He has been taken there."

Tobious looked up.

"My men have to walk those stairs," Therren said. "I want the man who knows the drain to survive. I want him capable of telling us whether the ground will go under our feet."

It was not kindness. Tobious could use the result without mistaking it for kindness.

"How bad?"

"Bad enough that she asked for splints, oil, and two hands she trusts. I gave her the hands."

Therren stood. The scribe followed. At the door, the captain paused.

"Someone who knows the device is coming. My commission is to deliver the site in working order. Darran's is to find it. Those are different obligations."

"Who gave him his?"

Therren opened the door. "Ask him."



Near dusk, they marched Tobious back to the ancestor terrace. The well's stone rim was bright with late sun. The statue of the woman with the bowl had been propped against the wall of the old storehouse, still wrapped in cloth, as though she were waiting for another household to claim her.

Samon was not among the workers clearing the approach. Tobious knew better than to hope he would be.

Darran and Therren stood beside a stranger in plain dark clothes. The man was older than the captain, his hair silver at the temples. He had the stillness of someone saving his breath for work, though when he turned, his left knee delayed him slightly. A narrow case hung at his side.

The stranger spoke to Darran in a language Tobious could not follow. Darran answered too quickly. The stranger held out his hand, and after a moment Darran gave him the drawing.

Then the man addressed Tobious in Aras speech, marked by an unfamiliar coast in the vowels.

"You touched the broken regulator."

"I cleared mud from it."

"And after that?"

"A man appeared. Then the passage opened. Something came through."

The stranger did not ask whether Tobious had dreamed any of it. He unrolled the hide, traced a line near the pierced circle, and folded it away.

"I am Panjios."

"Who sent you?"

"A warning from the coast. One of the older stations still sends a signal when this one wakes."

"Older than what?"

"Older than the stones around it."

Tobious glanced toward Darran. "He was trying to wake it."

“Yes,” Panjios said. He did not make Darran bear the whole answer. “Someone supplied him with the drawing. I intend to learn who accepted the request and why.”

Darran gave a short laugh. “You brought the authorization.”

Panjios turned the hide over. Pressed into one corner was a small device of three lines enclosing a gap. Tobious recognized it: the same mark beside the order Darran had shown underground. On Panjios's case, a metal tag bore it in relief.

“The permission to inspect a buried site,” Panjios said, “is not permission to open an unstable route with unprotected workers.”

Therren cut in. “If the inspection is yours, inspect it. If it's unsafe, tell me how to keep my people alive. I have no men to spare for a dispute over whose seal means what.”

Panjios asked to see the lower chamber. He told the captain he would enter first. Tobious was brought along because Panjios needed him to describe exactly where the light had formed.

Below, the walls seemed ordinary. A broken basket lay where one worker had dropped it. Someone had washed the dead guard's blood from the lower step, and the dark water had carried it to the drain Tobious had opened.

Panjios stopped before the fallen beam. His fingers passed above it without touching. A dim line gathered around his forearm and widened until it surrounded him from shoulder to boot. It had no hard edge; Tobious saw it best where dust drifting down the stairs changed direction before reaching his clothes.

The soldier behind Tobious drew a breath.

Panjios looked back. “Only I am protected. Keep your distance.”

He approached the lower doorway. The black surface was inert. The bent clamp had fallen against the frame, trapping a band of green metal beneath it. Panjios knelt and opened the case at his side.

Inside lay a short dark blade with a narrow powered seam along one side. Its grip was wrapped in plain, unmarked material. It was not the great weapon Tobious had imagined when he had lain on the paving and wished for a sword. It looked like a tool someone had kept because it worked.

Panjios set the blade against the fouled metal.

The light around his body went out.

“Back,” he said.

He held the edge in place. A faint thread of brightness ran along the green band, then through it. Three breaths passed before the metal parted. Panjios withdrew the blade and a shimmer returned around him.

The soldier behind Tobious swore softly. Darran came down from the passage with another man and shoved past them to see the frame. The second man, a young guard with a bandage at his neck, saw the severed clamp and raised his spear toward Tobious.

“He did that yesterday,” the guard said. “My brother is dead.”

Panjios was still crouching. He turned between Tobious and the spear. Bronze struck the shimmer at his shoulder and stopped an arm's length from cloth. The impact pushed Panjios back against the stone. He did not look invulnerable. He let the force move him, found his footing, and lowered his empty hand.

“Your brother died,” he said. “No one here is going to make that untrue by killing another man.”

“He opened it.”

“The part I cut was already broken. The next opening was forced.”

The guard looked to Darran. Darran said nothing. Therren had followed them down; he took the spear from his soldier and sent him up with another man.

Tobious watched Panjios close the case. He had seen three things in less than a minute: a blow stopped in the air, a blade that could cut a substance unknown to any smith in Aras, and the brief interval when the one who held that blade had no protection at all.

“What was the thing?” Tobious asked.

“An Iwang.” Panjios glanced at the dark frame. “People on this shore have an older name for them. The Hollow Ones.”

“There are more?”

“Yes.”

Tobious wanted a gentler answer. He trusted this one further.

Panjios touched the place where the clamp had sat. “This station is shut for now. It won't stay that way without repair. The broken regulator used you to steady its first contact.”

“Used me how?”

"I can explain what we've measured. I won't pretend it answers everything."

They returned to the light above. On the ancestor terrace, Lios was helping gather the fallen fragments of his jug into a cloth. He paused when Tobious emerged. A bruise darkened the side of his neck, but there was no rope on it.

Tobious stepped toward him. A soldier blocked the way.

"He isn't free," Lios said before Tobious could ask.

The boy said it matter-of-factly, as one might report that the jug could not be mended. Then he bent back over the pieces.



Panjios asked to speak with Tobious where the captain could hear them. That was no assurance of honesty, but it changed the shape of the trap. Darran could no longer pretend that his instructions came from the same authority as Panjios's warning without being challenged.

"The damaged route needs a living reference," Panjios said. "At present, that is you. If we try to force it from you, we may injure you and open it badly. If you learn to hold it safely, we may be able to repair what Darran damaged."

"Where do you want to take me?"

"Across the coast station, to the city you saw."

The city. The man who might be Tobious. The road falling with people on it. Tobious looked at the bay until the vessels moving there were just dark strokes against the sun.

"You can take me there," he said, "and bring me back?"

"There are return procedures. They have limits. I won't promise a day I haven't measured."

"What about Aras?"

"We can provision a small number of households and treat the injured while the route is secured."

"All of them?"

"Not on the authority I carry."

"Then ask for it."

"I will. That is different from telling you it has been granted."

Tobious looked at Therren. The captain's expression did not soften. He was weighing a future worker against an immediate one.

"Samon needs a splint made properly and something for pain," Tobious said. "Lios goes to his own people. And the seed your men took gets replaced. Before I leave."

"Those are three demands," Therren said.

"You counted fourteen jars yesterday. You're able to count three."

Panjios did not smile. "I can bring dressings and a brace fitted to the leg. I can bring grain equal to what I can carry through Salt Gate on the next scheduled opening. I can arrange for the boy's release from this labor assignment. Therren must agree to that last part."

The captain glanced toward Lios. "A broken jug has made him expensive."

"Then take my labor against it," Tobious said.

"Your labor is already taken."

Panjios said, "The stores I bring will be entered under my seal, not his. There will be a written count and a local witness."

Therren thought for some time. At last he nodded once. "The boy goes to the village. Your supplies may pass. Darran will not touch the lower frame until your people repair it."

Darran began to object. Therren silenced him with a hand.

Tobious had the sensation of watching men divide a field that belonged to neither of them. Yet Samon could receive care. Lios could sleep somewhere without a rope. A little grain could return. There was a price on each thing, and he would be the one to go.

"I haven't agreed," he said.

Panjios met his eyes. "No."

"I need to speak to Mariya."

"Then speak to her. At the lower granary before morning. The supplies should be there by then."

They released Tobious from the soldiers' hold. He reached Lios before anyone could call him back. The boy was tying the cloth around his broken jug.

"You can go home," Tobious said.

Lios looked past him at Therren, waiting for the order to be taken back. The captain turned away.

"My aunt's on the lower street," Lios said. "She'll be angry about the jug."

"Let her be angry at me."

"She knows who breaks things."

Lios tucked the bundle under his arm and ran before a soldier could invent another task for him.

Tobious watched him go. The boy had asked to keep the pieces of a vessel he could no longer use. Perhaps his aunt would know how to mend it. Perhaps she would give him another and he would refuse, because this one was his.

Panjios came to stand beside Tobious, leaving him room to walk away.

"A city isn't an answer to a village," Tobious said.

"No."

"And a sword isn't one either."

"It may help you bring an answer home."

Tobious studied the older man's hand. Its knuckles bore small scars where the blade's case had rubbed them over years. It was a working hand, though it had learned a work Tobious did not know.

"Show Mariya the grain," Tobious said. "Then we'll talk."



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